

APOLOGIA PRO DUCE

The chief and perhaps sole importance of Luigi Villari's *Italian Foreign Policy under Mussolini* (New York: Devon-Adair, 1956) lies in the fact that it was published at all. Luigi Villari is described by his publishers as a "great scholar," and his work is called a "serious contribution to the historical record of our times," but Mr. Villari is, in fact, not a scholar at all; he is a notorious fascist propagandist who at the age of eighty-one is still insisting that Mussolini was always right, and his book could be regarded as history only by fervent fascists and all other gullible people who might believe that there is more than the slightest merit in "the other side of the case." If Mr. Villari's cherished system had ever prevailed, we can be sure that its defeated enemies would have found no firm of Devon-Adair to bring out their side of the argument.

Revision and re-interpretation are not only legitimate in historical study, they may well be its life breath, and the informed reader has a right to know facts that have been obscured by the smoke of battle and the smell of polemic. But to perpetuate lies, to insist on a palpably distorted version of events and to praise the rightness of a cause that was one of the worst ever in the world is to do serious injury to history and present an insult to the reader's intelligence. Unfortunately, there is an audience for this kind of revisionism. Disenchantment and disillusion are

natural enough when the golden age does not succeed immediately on the sacrifices made to attain it, and it is always possible to believe that the evils of "before the war" (whichever war that may be) were not really as great as those that confront us today. Thus, that good father of his people, Benito Mussolini, can now appear as one who never wished or did any harm, who raised his loving children from the status of "Wops" — as *Time* told us in July of 1936 — and who was finally and ungratefully martyred at Dongo. Here is a particularly attractive image to be venerated by the ignorant, the bewildered and the congenitally wrongheaded. After all, he did not actually kill as many people as did Hitler or Stalin (or Genghis Khan); he received abundant praise from Winston Churchill and other statesmen with equal reputations for consistency and a sense of moral proportion, and, finally, fascism was widely praised in America except by the counterparts of Mussolini's Italian enemies. These enemies, according to Villari, belong to the vague but commodious category of "malcontents," or they are in the mixed bag of socialists, liberals, communists and, of course, rich Jews who are loyal only to the regime that they set up in Moscow. In fact, and here is a revelation, Mussolini's enemies have only one crime in common; they are "anti-fascists."

As we well know, Mussolini's many friends in America, Britain and France turned

against him only when they realized that his foreign policy was really as mad as it had always sounded. To Mr. Villari this is nearly incomprehensible wickedness, for his hero would have saved us all from communism and worse if he had only been listened to. Then again, the author holds that the western conspiracy against fascist foreign policy was actually inspired by a wide-spread aversion to fascism, something concerning Italians alone. So it goes, double-think and no-think, hand in hand, just so long as the Duce is always right. It is bad enough that Mussolini's supposed realism led his country to ruin and almost into the hands of a formidable communist party and that his essential encouragement of Hitler brought Russia far to the west, but it is far worse to realize that he based himself on the unforgivable crime of despising his fellow men. Villari joins then in insulting the dignity of all Italians who remained men while they toiled like beasts for the good of their children and the love of their land. Villari is at his warmest when he praises Mussolini because he was fundamentally a journalist and saw all with a journalist's eye, but are we to believe, as we easily can from this account, that he did it all for publicity? Are we to believe also that the headlines and bloody excitement were worth the price to those poor people who needed "discipline," those builders of rocky terraces, pruners of vines and back-crooked wielders of the

ancestral *zappa*? Luigi Villari's distinctions remain those he had at birth — a reputable historian for a father and a talented Englishwoman for a mother.

[George T. Romani]

MORAVIA'S AND SOLDATI'S NEW HEROINES

The two outstanding fictional works of the quarter are again by authors known to the English-reading public: *La ciociara*, by Alberto Moravia (Milan: Bompiani, 1957) and *Il vero Silvestri* ("The Real Silvestri") by Mario Soldati (Milan: Garzanti, 1957) whose earlier novel, *The Capri Letters*, was brought out by Knopf last year. Moravia and Soldati, extremely different as they are as literary artists, have in common an emphasis on craftsmanship, a routine professional quality, which is not too usual among respectable writers. This quality is reflected, as a matter of fact, also in their practical life. Moravia is not only a novelist but a constant contributor to daily and weekly newspapers, a co-editor of the quarterly *Nuovi Argomenti*, and the film critic of *L'Espresso*. He writes a more or less definite number of pages every morning in a modern apartment in an ancient section of Rome; incidentally, this to him is not only the result of a natural impulse but also a necessary antidote to a basic sense of boredom. Soldati, on the other hand, while his contributions to periodicals are sporadic, makes most of his living as a film director.

Both novels are in the first person; they use fictional narrators. This device, as any practitioner knows, is an easy temptation because it solves certain problems of point of view and speech, and gives the narrative a sort of *a priori* truthfulness. Both novels here adopt it with a sufficient sense of artistic necessity. Soldati, as in his earlier collection of stories, *A cena col commendatore* ("Dinner with the Knight-Commander;" Milan: Longanesi, 1952), uses as his mouthpiece a character not too vastly different from himself — a man, that is, subtly articulate, temperamental, capable of keen psychological insights. In Moravia's case the "speaker" is a *ciociara*, or woman from the Ciociaria, the pastoral region south of Rome of which Fondi is the main town. In other words, like his earlier "woman of Rome," his protagonist-narrator may "talk too well for a woman of the people."

La ciociara, then, is in Moravia's third manner. The first manner was that of the early novels and short stories which had mainly to do with the Roman upper-middle-class; some readers still consider it Moravia's best, in the treatment for instance of adolescent characters like the hero of the old *Inverno di malato* ("A Sick Boy's Winter," not known in English because it was written before Moravia, and generally Italy, became fashionable) or those of the later *Two Adolescents*. The narrator was the anonymous all-seeing observer, with an implicit touch of the

moralist. The second manner was that of the stories collected in the Bompiani complete works as "surrealist and satiric tales." Moravia has been for at least twenty years a great admirer of Kafka; add to this the fact that, during fascism, an allegorical and cryptographic sort of writing was a way to make a virtue out of necessity. The satiric novel *La mascherata* ("The Fancy Dress Party," a satire on fascism), is the product of that phase which is best known outside Italy, because publishers are generally keen on anything that smacks of topical interest, and make a fatal confusion between the appeal of literature and that of reportage. However, any of the stories contained in the volume cited above, would represent that second manner more satisfactorily. The third, and present manner, is a popular one, from the points of view both of subject matter and reading public; it consists of *The Woman of Rome*, of the present novel, and of dozens of short stories (the series is still running), the "Roman tales." These stories first appear in the daily *Corriere della sera*, generally on Sundays; they are looked forward to by "average readers;" a group of them have been made into a Cinemascope production directed by Gianni Franciolini.

Curiously, while the fictional narrators of the two novels are women, the narrator-hero of the stories is most typically a version of the same recurrent young man, a Roman of the

"lower classes," enterprising, basically amiable, job-chasing, moving among love troubles, petty intrigues, etc. One interesting problem in all of these stories, as well as in the present novel, is that of the adoption, by a "national" literary work, of local speech forms; at times Moravia's narrative can be described as semi-vernacular. This is made workable, of course, not only by the first-person device but also by the fact that the Roman vernacular is particularly close to general Italian.

For its background *La ciociara* can be listed as a war novel; it concentrates, however, on the destinies of two particular women from the Ciociaria, Cesira and her daughter Rosetta. The war compels them to leave Rome, where the mother owns a flourishing store, and try to obtain safety and food among their native mountains. They happen to spend most of the time close to the Garigliano river and to the slowly moving battlefield. The novel then is peopled with characters or local farmers, greedy and opportunistic black-marketeers, stray soldiers of all armies. In spite of his realism, there is a tendency in Moravia to produce symbolic types, characters possessing what he once referred to as a proverbial flavor; thus the principal male character in the novel, Michele, is the Young Idealist, roughly similar to the one in the *Woman of Rome*. A degree of oversimplification does not make him less plausible and truthful; in fact, if

the novel were real life, and the young man had not been killed by the Nazis, he would probably now be sitting in Parliament, classified, say, as Independent Left.

La ciociara has considerable interest as a document of the period and place which it covers (Moravia himself for a time had to seek refuge in very much such a place); naturally it goes beyond that, and declaredly intends to be, above all, the "description of two acts of violence, one collective and the other individual, war and rape." The main victim of the latter act, in the most daringly melodramatic scene in the book, is the daughter Rosetta, raped under the very eyes of the Virgin, in a church, by Moroccan soldiers. The stupefied indifference with which she accepts her following sexual destiny is the simple symbol of the moral aftermath of war and violence. The author is committed to that simplicity by the very choice of the *ciociara* as his heroine and narrator; a novel of this sort stands or falls on our interest in the narrator's outlook and speech. The fascination it may have, and the reason for its probable success, say, among Americans who fought in Italy, is that while it shows events which have been widely reported on and frequently presented in fiction and films, it does so from the visual angle of one of their obscure, anonymous heroines, a strong-willed woman with a taste for story-telling and a tendency to a simple sort of philosophizing. Through

this, many pages of the book (such as the description of the doomed and beautiful Russian soldier dragging two horses not his own and quietly expecting only death; or Cesira's dream vision of Mussolini's and Hitler's destruction, and her own reflections on Liberation) achieve a sort of fresh and genuine greatness.

Soldati's novel, though hardly related to public events, bears, instead, the flavor of post-war moral confusions among the well-to-do. The narrator, who is a bachelor of fifty and a successful lawyer, is called on a job to France and drives through Alpine regions which are particularly dear to his (and Soldati's) heart. In a small winter-sports shop near the border he unexpectedly recognizes, in the shopkeeper's woman companion, Aurora, a lady he had known years before in a totally different milieu: actually, in that mixture of the slick and the ambiguous which is epitomized by certain aspects of the section of Rome called Parioli. He had then known Aurora as the wife of one of his rich clients, later departed for Brazil; and as the object of the desperate and unrequited love of his own best friend, Silvestri. The novel, a short one to be sure, consists of the reconstruction, through dialogue and flashback, of the past history of these people and of the attempt on the part of the narrator to establish the true nature of their relationships. This is done not only with great subtlety, cleverly exploiting the gradual process

of psychological detective work to create suspense; but also with a deep undercurrent of moral preoccupation, the sense of a biting and alert conscience, so that the story of the gradual discovery of "the true Silvestri" becomes, in its limited way, a study on the nature of love and friendship.

Neither *La ciociara* nor *Il vero Silvestri* adds a new dimension to Moravia's and Soldati's work; but this fact can be seen optimistically. Italy has always lacked a sufficient number of novelists who can be counted on to provide, at reasonable intervals, respectable even if predictable books. Routine products such as these can be helpful in establishing more firmly the novel as a popular art and a recognized institution.

[P. M. P.]

WORDS ARE STONES

In his new book *Le parole sono pietre* (Turin: Einaudi, 1956) soon to appear in English translation, Carlo Levi the well-known author of *Christ Stopped at Eboli* returns after a number of years to the poverty-stricken regions of southern Italy that inspired his best work. In his description of this world of the "Mezzogiorno," we find again those qualities that we had missed in his symbolic novel *L'Orologio*, and that are really most genuinely characteristic of him: the ability to set the most insignificant details of the landscape in relief; and what amounts to his real vocation — the illumination

through words and stories of the primitive passions of these peasants.

Levi's destination is Sicily; his objective, to carry out a newspaper assignment and to satisfy his innate curiosity about people and places. But his is not the idle curiosity of the tourist who seeks the picturesque and is carried away by a sunset on the water. His aspiration is to read what is behind these faces closed in an impenetrable silence, and to decipher the age-old secret of Sicily's land, at times so luxurious, at times so barren and primitive. He proceeds on his trip with his eyes wide open, divining behind a simple gesture of the people he meets, a change of mood—anger, resignation, or hope; gathering the drama of life from nature itself, from the permanence of that dazzling light that falls on Sicily like a yellow falcon falling on the countryside covered with stubble. The landscape is never depicted solely for its own sake, but as it complements and illuminates the lives and gestures of those who people it. For the men and the land spring from the same origin, from the same profound vitality, actors perhaps in a remote drama whose words do not reach our ears. And just as these men co-exist with nature and are themselves nature, so rare indeed are their gestures and spoken words, so in nature, life and death co-exist. The blue sky of Sicily, "tragic, ardent, unbelievable," exists beside the calcified bones, the burned skeleton of Monte Pel-

legrino. "Actually in this Sicily where the past is as if annulled by the permanent luminosity of nature, death is itself life. And life is often not different from death."

Levi gives two excellent examples of this global vision of the Sicilian nature which, as it does not know life and death, so it is also ignorant of good and evil. The first is the description, devoid of human sympathy but full of pictorial appreciation, of the owner of a sulphur mine during a strike. His impassive face seems to belong to an age of which we have only an archaic, hereditary memory. It is the face of a man from a prehistoric world.

The second example we find in that magnificent *kermesse funèbre* that is the visit of the writer to the embalmed corpses of the cemetery of the Capuchin monks in Palermo. Here is none of the admonishing warning to the living of the medieval Dance Macabre, but only the presence of the dead among the living. The nicely arranged expressions on the corpse's faces, those bushy, neatly trimmed beards, those multicolored and varied costumes, seem not to want to hide death from the living, but on the contrary to show that death preserves completely in itself the image of life.

Levi knows how to see beyond all social distinctions to the natural and instinctive conflicts in the hearts of his characters. Beyond the problem of wealth and poverty that divides the protagonists into two groups, one armed against the